

We don't usually do memes, but when we do...

All right we can't resist anymore. The meme-force is just too strong. We have finally given in and decided to appease our millennial overlords by having memes in the magazine. Heck, we've dedicated this entire issue to memes!

Memes are more interesting than you'd think. Without spoiling anything in the cover story, I can tell you that they are more than just the images that you see widely circulated online. Memes as a concept was first thought of to be analogous to genes – the fundamental replicators responsible for evolution of life on earth. Memes can be loosely thought of as cultural units of transmission. They survive. They adapt. And they evolve.

Speaking of adaptation and evolution, Digit too has evolved a lot since its inception. We've gone through two major redesigns, gone from CDs to two dual-layer DVDs, then back to one, started a lifestyle section called dgt, introduced tons of new booklets like dmystify, Encyclopedia Technica, and so many more that I'm probably forgetting...

However, despite all these major and incremental changes, the next evolutionary leap – transitioning the mag to the digital realm – hadn't been made. The need had been apparent to us longer than you'd think, but just like genes need a favourable environment to thrive, the mag too needed environmental factors to match.

We've been watching the digital publishing space for a while now, but there always seemed to be some hiccup or the other. If the platform was good, the price was prohibitive, or if the solution was affordable, it was nothing more than a glorified RSS reader, or worse, merely a PDF file to be viewed on a screen. Digit was available on Magzter and Read-Where in those formats, but they were pretty lame, to be honest. Heck people actually did some creative coding to find workarounds for the security of one of those sites, and before you knew it,



Siddharth Parwatay
Managing Editor

"Despite incremental changes, the next evolutionary leap for the mag hadn't been made"

Digit PDFs were being distributed on P2P networks.

We didn't really care too much to be honest, because reading a magazine in PDF on a phone is such a pain that if someone was willing to undergo all that torture, we figured they had earned the right to read it.

Then there was the problem of which platform to design for. About 3 or 4 years ago we wasted a good 6 months designing our magazine for tablets, knowing fully well that tablets would never be mass. This was because mobile screen sizes and resolutions were still playing catch up. To date, Wired and the like are available only on tablets. We wanted to be available on your primary device... your smartphone. So we had to wait. However, technology really wasn't the biggest problem though, because we're usually on top of such things.

The bigger factor that made us wait until 2017 to properly launch the app (which might seem shocking to most), is that you guys just weren't willing to pay for content in anything but the offline / print form. When I say you guys, I mean

the Indian technology reader in general, not specifically the print readers. Till about mid-July last year, just about 3.1 per cent of mobile app users in India were spending money on in-app purchases compared to 5.2 per cent globally. But the good news was that the trend was on an upward swing.

A kick in the pants for all of us was the demonetisation drive. Regardless of your views about it, you can't argue with the fact that it did force a lot of people to use digital payments and get used to using their smartphones for something other than clicking pictures, chatting and using social media.

Despite it being 2017 already, we're still probably one of the very first tech publications in the world to have an app to read a print magazine on a smartphone. Heck, there are not too many magazines that will offer you the readability that we are, and the time is now right.

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